

Main

Report Name (Org_Country_Year_Report Type)

FOOP_Sierra Leone_2024-25_3-month Report

Fellowship Organization

Farming out of Poverty (FOOP)

Fellowship City

Freetown

Fellowship Country

Sierra Leone

Fellowship Start Date

09/02/2024

Anticipated Fellowship End Date

09/02/2025

What is your fellowship title/role?

Project Impact Coordinator

What are your primary responsibilities?

1. I lead the monitoring and evaluation (M&E) team, which is a team of 4 data collectors, based in Tormabum, while I'm based in Freetown. I'm helping to build the department as it is new.
2. I co-write grant applications.
3. I write social media posts and oversee posting on LinkedIn.

I receive adequate direction and support to perform my fellowship responsibilities.

Agree

Did you receive any sort of orientation, handover or onboarding when you started your fellowship?

Somewhat

Please describe your orientation/onboarding and note who handled it.

One of my supervisors sent me documents to learn more about the organization's work and had a few brief meetings with me to go over what I read.

If you did not receive any kind of orientation, what information or guidance were you provided at the start of your fellowship?**Describe a representative day at work.**

I start my day at 9 a.m., greeting my coworkers in Krio and making my morning coffee or tea. After checking emails, I connect with the field team via WhatsApp to stay updated on their activities and provide support as needed. My work varies throughout the week—some days, I focus on grant writing or social media posting to share our impact, while other days, I prepare evaluation surveys to assess program outcomes. I regularly meet with my supervisors, including the Executive Director and Program Coordinator, for debriefings and strategic discussions. Occasionally, I attend virtual training sessions hosted by our partner organizations, which help build nonprofit capacity and enhance our work. Each day is purposeful and contributes to our mission of empowering farmers and communities.

On average, how many hours per week do you work?

40 hours

How would you describe your effectiveness in your fellowship post so far?

Effective

Please briefly describe 1-2 specific projects that you have undertaken or accomplishments you have made so far.

1. I co-wrote 4 grant applications. The organization ended up securing a \$15,000 grant.
2. I co-developed the indicators for the organization's new M&E framework.
3. I am leading the evaluation of our new financial literacy program for women in rural areas. I have designed the baseline survey and compiled and tested it on KoboToolbox.

What is your organization's work culture like?**What is your office environment like? Please comment on the size and structure of the office(s) where you do most of your work.**

We have an open plan office space and 9 employees. There are 2 offices, one for the Executive Director and Program Coordinator, and another for the rest of the employees. I rotate between both offices but I mainly work in the office where the rest of the employees work. While the office is our base, much of our work also involves regular communication with field teams and occasional visits to project sites, which keeps us connected to the communities we serve.

To whom do you report?

I report to the Executive Director and the Program Coordinator. I work with the ED on grants and donor relations. I work with the PC on Monitoring and Evaluation.

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Have you had an initial check-in with your supervisor to set up a work plan and to set goals for your work during your fellowship year?

No

Was this meeting helpful in understanding your role and setting goals for your fellowship year?

Please explain why you have not met with your supervisor and if you have plans to do so going forward.

I did not think I needed a work plan at first but now I feel like I need one so I am going to meet with one of my supervisors to prepare one.

Please briefly indicate 3-5 professional goals you have for the rest of your fellowship year. Your professional goals should align with your work plan.

1. I plan to be more involved in data analysis and report writing.
2. I plan to take professional courses provided by partner organizations as part of my professional development.
3. I plan to take on an independent project within the organization.

How often do you check in with your supervisor?

Irregularly

Have you had an opportunity to travel for work so far?

Yes

Describe this travel opportunity. Include location(s) and a brief description of the purpose of the trip(s).

Every month, I travel to Tormabum village, where the operational hub is located. I travel for the purpose of interacting with staff on the ground and checking in on my Monitoring and Evaluation team.

I feel adequately prepared for my position's professional responsibilities.

Agree

Please briefly explain your response.

I have some monitoring and evaluation and grant writing experience.

How did you travel to your host country and site? Please be specific

My organization purchased my ticket for me. I'm not sure where they bought it. I flew on Ethiopian Airlines from Gaborone to Addis Ababa, and Addis Ababa to Accra. I also flew on Asky Airlines from Accra to Lungi. I took a Seacoach ferry from Lungi to Freetown. My organization could not buy a ticket with a return date that is after a full year, so they bought a ticket that allowed them to change the return date later. The round trip ticket cost \$1456.

What kind of visa/ permit do you have or applied for?

I obtained a landing visa and a 1-year residence permit.

How did you obtain (or are obtaining) your visa or permit?

I obtained it through my organization. They coordinated the whole process for me.

Did you apply for and receive your visa / permit before heading to your host country or after arriving?

My organization applied for the visa before I arrived and for the permit after I arrived.

What costs were associated with obtaining your visa or permit?

The landing visa cost \$35. The residence permit cost \$150.

Did you pay the visa / permit costs or were they covered by your organization?

The costs were covered by my organization.

Are you still having challenges obtaining your visa/ permit?

No

If yes, please explain further

g) Do you have any suggestions to help future Fellows navigate the visa / permit application process?

NA

What vaccinations were you required to obtain prior to your departure? How much did your vaccinations cost? Did you get a yellow fever vaccination?

I was required to get a yellow fever vaccination. I got it for free at a public clinic in my home country.

How was your arrival and first week in your host country? Any improvements that could streamline the assimilation process for future Fellows?

The first week was great. I arrived at the airport in Lungi and bought my SIM card there. I also had to pay a \$25 security fee. I advise carrying some dollars to pay the security fee because it's required of everyone flying into the country. You will also need to get a SIM card ASAP to communicate with the FOOP team so that they can pick you up and take you home. After arriving at the airport, I took a ferry with Seacoach to Freetown. After arriving at the port in Freetown, I spent 3 hours waiting for my bags as they came in separate ferries.

The office assistant was waiting for me at the port and held up a sign with the organization's name. He, with another staff member, drove me to my place. He also took me shopping to buy any last minute necessities. I was grateful that my apartment was already set up and that I did not have to secure it myself.

The first week at the office was great too. One of my supervisors let me get off work early and took me shopping for any necessities, while also showing me around. I also put in a request for household supplies like ironing boards, which the organization bought for me. Overall, my experience was great and everyone was supportive.

Is housing provided by and/or paid for by your organization? Please explain.

Housing is provided and paid for by the organization. You do not have to look for the housing yourself and you do not have to use your stipend to cover it.

Do you live in a location that is more urban or rural?

Very Urban

Please describe your living environment

I live in a busy urban area with a lot of traffic and activity.

How do you typically travel between your home and your work? How much does your daily transportation cost and how long is your commute?

I take an e-rickshaw, which is locally known as a keke, to a place called Kingtom Bridge. From there, I take a motorbike to my workplace. The keke costs 15 Leones (\$0.66) and the bike costs 5 Leones (\$0.22). On a good day without traffic and with short wait times, the commute takes about 25 minutes.

If you live in a more rural area, what are the closest urban areas you can travel to for shopping, airport, larger medical centers, etc.?

NA

How is the weather in your host country? What season are you presently in?

There are 2 seasons: the dry season and the rainy season. We are currently in the dry season. It is very hot and dry.

What is the appropriate clothing for work and outside of work at your fellowship post and in your community in general?

The dress code at work is smart casual. Outside of work, women can wear short and tight-fitting clothing.

How have you been spending your free time?

I have been meeting up with fellow expats working for different organizations. We visit different places such as the beach and local restaurants.

I've been able to successfully navigate my personal/social life both back at home and at my fellowship post.

Agree

Please briefly explain your response below.

I have been able to successfully navigate my personal and social life. I have met friends through my co-workers who then introduce me to more friends.

Would you say you live and work in a safe area?

I am not sure about the level of crime where I live as I am new and I haven't heard of any incidents, but it is a busy urban area so I can only imagine that there is some crime. However, I feel safe and even though I feel safe, I still take precautions and I'm careful with my belongings.

What precautions do you take to ensure your safety?

During my commute, I use trusted transportation options and avoid traveling alone at night whenever possible. I stay alert and aware of my surroundings, particularly in crowded areas. I avoid using my phone when I am in public. At home, I ensure that doors and windows are securely locked.

What has been your experience with crime so far? (Please note that any security or safety concerns or incidents should be reported directly to PiAf staff per PiAf safety and security protocol.)

I have not had any experience with crime.

Describe the incidence of crime and the general security situation within your city/town. Could you recommend specific areas future Fellows might consider for safe housing? What about areas that should be avoided?

Not sure about the incidence of crime or areas with safe housing.

Please refer back to the goals you set for yourself before orientation. Are you working towards these goals? Have you met any of them? Changed any of them? Please explain.

I am gaining valuable experience in M&E and contributing significantly to building the M&E department. I designed an evaluation survey for a financial literacy program and co-developed the indicators for the M&E framework. I will also lead the annual impact measurement and the organization's flagship Poverty Stoplight survey.

Beyond work, I've made meaningful connections within my host community. I enjoy a friendly rapport with my coworkers in both Freetown and Tormabum and have formed strong relationships with the Tormabum community.

I have connected with other fellows through the PiAf affinity groups and our fellows group chat but I hope to build more connections with PiAf fellows. I have been intentional about reaching out to people to seek support and guidance, especially my alumni mentor.

Learning Krio has been a personal goal, though finding affordable local tutors has been challenging. My coworkers often switch to English when Krio becomes too complex for me, so I've mostly mastered basic greetings. I also have my graduate school applications consuming most of my free time. Still, I am determined to persevere and aim to achieve fluency in the coming months.

I have also been intentional about admitting when I don't know something. I ask my supervisors for help and direction, as well as my team in Tormabum for help.

Do you have any frustrations with your living arrangements, your work or your life outside of work?

While I am generally satisfied with my work and living arrangements, I find it difficult to coordinate and meet with my team in Tormabum. We are often hindered by lack of electricity, poor internet or busy schedules as they have to do a lot of work on the field. One solution we have come up with was to meet on Friday evenings, when everyone is likely to be available.

Has there been anything that you have needed but have not been able to locate or acquire?

I needed to find a testing center to write my GRE but there were none available. I had to test from home but because of the unstable power and internet, I booked an office space for peace of mind.

I have also been unable to find prescription medication at local pharmacies, but luckily my doctor was able to prescribe good alternatives.

How have you dealt with "culture shock"?

I have approached culture shock by talking about it to friends, family, and colleagues. My alumni mentor, who is also Sierra Leonean, has been really great at helping me make sense of my experiences.

What about your experience thus far has been the most...surprising?

One of the most surprising aspects of my experience has been how expensive things are here, especially compared to what I initially expected. Basic necessities like groceries, transportation, and even utilities often cost more than anticipated. For example, imported goods are significantly marked up, making it difficult to stick to a budget without careful planning.

This has been a valuable learning experience, as it's given me a deeper appreciation for the economic challenges faced by many in the community. It has also encouraged me to adapt by seeking out local markets, negotiating prices where appropriate, and being more mindful of my spending habits. While the cost of living has been surprising, it has also highlighted the importance of resourcefulness and adaptability in this environment.

What about your experience thus far has been the most...challenging?

Banking has been one of the most challenging aspects of my experience. I use Access Bank, but the lack of reliable banking services often forces me to carry large amounts of cash, which can be inconvenient and concerning. The online banking app frequently malfunctions,

making it difficult to send money digitally, and my debit card is not accepted in stores.

Additionally, Access Bank has limited ATM availability, and the few ATMs that exist are often out of service unless you go to the main office. As a result, I am forced to withdraw cash in person at the bank, which is only open during weekday working hours. Given the high cost of living, I often need to withdraw large amounts, as expenses quickly deplete my cash reserves.

The entire process feels cumbersome, and I would greatly appreciate more efficient online or mobile banking services. This experience has highlighted the importance of accessible financial systems, especially in settings where cash remains the primary mode of transaction.

What are the top 3 things you miss the most from your home country or the U.S.?

1. Efficient banking and financial services
2. Ease of transportation
3. Reliable utilities such as electricity

What are the top 3 things about life in your host country that beat out life in your home country or the U.S.?

1. The internet quality
2. The local food
3. How open and friendly strangers are here

How is your stipend being paid?

a) Monthly b) In Leones c) Local account

How are you receiving your stipend funds?

Wire

Did you raise funds to cover part of your fellowship expenses?

No, I did not raise funds.

Yes, I have taken additional work during my fellowship year.

Please list any additional one-time or infrequent expenses not included in your monthly budget below.

Monthly Budget

Rent	Utilities	Furnishings	Phone	Home Security	Internet
\$0.00	\$0.00	\$0.00	\$0.00	\$0.00	\$42.00
Transportation	Fitness	Entertainment	Groceries	House Cleaning	Eating Out
\$70.00	\$0.00	\$2.99	\$105.00	\$0.00	\$26.00
Medications	Additional Health Insurance	Travel	Laundry	Other	Total Monthly Budget (Minus Entertainment & Travel)
\$70.00	\$0.00	\$3.00	\$1.00	\$0.00	314.00
Specify "Other"					

Final Thoughts

Please briefly explain your response about Orientation.

Yes. The orientation was very comprehensive and it pushed me to read the handbook more closely to make sure I was adequately prepared.

Is there anything in particular that PiAf could cover at orientation that would have better prepared you for your fellowship post? Please specify.

No

Are you receiving sufficient support, materials and information from the Princeton in Africa office? What could we improve?

Yes

As we plan the upcoming PiAf Retreat, we hope to incorporate some Fellow suggestions into our programming. What are some topics or sessions you would like to see at the Retreat? (We appreciate your feedback however, we may not be able to accommodate all suggestions or requests this year.)

A yoga session would be great